

teachers to beauty queens. In what follows, we hope to give all of you a better picture of how women use technology, and get a feel for how tech-evolved they really are.

Harshini Shah, a Client Service Executive from Mumbai, perhaps puts it best: "Men are more interested in gadgets than women are, but times are changing. Currently, we women use technology purely for basic convenience. Take the case of a cell phone: paying extra for features such as Bluetooth, GPRS, etc., does not seem logical to us—unless we're going to use them. However, a phone with radio or MP3 support has become more of a necessity than a luxury to us, and we'll pay for it."

Too many men, on the other hand, buy stuff and features they don't really need—because of the "cool" factor. Men just seem to have a higher level of inquisitiveness. Whether that's a good or bad thing, we'll let you decide for yourself, but we men will sit and read manuals, and open up every screw, just to see what's underneath. Women—at least the ones we spoke to—are just happy when things work. They prefer to use and create only when necessary, and do not have the curiosity to take apart and see what makes something tick. Which is something you know, and which is a perfectly okay thing.

Anything But Pink

During our interviews, we found that women hated being stereotyped not just by men, but by companies as well. We asked them all whether they would be inclined to buy products targeted at women: pink MP3 players, or phones with calorie calculators, or a menstrual cycle timetable. This elicited an emphatic "No!" from most. Although looks were important to all the women we polled, all of them hated the clichéd women-only colour combinations of the devices targeted at them. As for calorie and menstrual cycle watchers, none of the women thought it too practical. Some did agree that they would like those features in their phones, so long as the devices were *not* pink or purple. Yes, that's right—and we believe manufacturers should take note.

We also quizzed the women about the importance of various parameters of personal devices, and asked them to rate Looks, Features, Price, Performance, and Customisability—in decreasing order of importance—when it came to a buying decision. The results? Features won by a landslide. Looks came next, then performance and price tied for third, and customisability came in last.

Loveleen Pasricha, a Sr. Image Manager at Media Solutions, Delhi, says, "The first thing to look for is whether I need the gadget. Next I look at the features it has, and try to find the best combination of the features I need and the most affordable price."

Software

When it comes to software, which is perhaps what all of us in the digital age use the most, the consensus was "easier to use." Of the ladies we spoke to, those who use Microsoft Office at work or home all seemed to have only praises for the MS Office suite. When asked how they would like software to be improved, a lot of women cited Office 2007's metamorphosis as significant—because a lot of fea-



My favourite software would have to be iTunes, because it's user friendly and I'm addicted to podcasts. I also love software that is skinnable and customisable. As for gadgets, I look for features and value for money; looks aren't really that important. I don't think gadgets and gizmos are targeted at just men anymore; I think they're unisex, and targeted more at different age groups."

Sarah-Jane Dias
Miss India World 2007

tures that were earlier hidden were now revealed. Interestingly, when we at *Digit* first started using the Office 2007 beta and trials, we found that the men resisted the changes more. Women seemed to adapt to it a lot faster. Today, of course, we all love the Ribbon, regardless of gender.

Gadgets Galore

Our little survey told us that most women have computers at home, and it seems laptops are the preferred PC solution. Some had both laptops and Desktops, while a minority had only a Desktop: roughly 70 per cent had laptops, and 20 per cent of those also owned Desktops (though the Desktops were all older models). This is consistent with the sales figures for increased laptop sales that all PC vendors are reporting—so women are right up there with changing technology trends.

Absolutely no surprise was the fact that everyone we polled owned a cell phone—men, women, children. Nokia was the popular choice, with a few Sony Ericssons thrown in, and hardly any of the others. However, interestingly, the majority of those who had bought a phone in the last two years made sure it had MP3 playback and camera functionality. Music and camera phones are the order of the day, with radio functionality coming in a close third.

The only exceptions to the music phone rules were those who own a portable media player. Again, no prizes for guessing which was the most popular: the iPod. Though there were a few who owned a Creative or a Philips portable media player, they're grossly outnumbered by iWomen...

Gaming

The women we polled admitted to only casual gaming. Cell phones and PCs were the favourite platform, followed by those addictive iPod games. Only a handful had a gaming console at home, and even then it was mostly because of the presence of a male sibling. However, almost 5 per cent had no male siblings, and still owned a gaming console. A wild guess tells us that this is not radically lower than the figures for males in India.

Cynthia Dsouza (Mumbai) and Loveleen Pasricha (Delhi) both have gaming consoles at home, and no male siblings that we could attribute this phenomenon to. They both just love their gaming, especially racing games, and spend over three hours a week on them—a lot when you consider that they're not college students but working professionals. Incidentally, Cynthia owns a PS2 and an Xbox 360, while Loveleen has a PS2 and a PSP; both are looking forward to buying a PS3.

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We have a joke going about the office about when a female colleague was asked to restart the computer by the System Admin over the phone. After several repeated calls, the admin went down to her floor to see what was wrong and found her switching her monitor on and off, trying to reboot! This was quite a few years ago, but perhaps we still tell such stories because we at *Digit* consider ourselves alpha-geeks, which automatically brings with it our chauvinism. But enough rambling...

What we're getting at is that women are generally the butt of technology jokes, and we found